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Renewal, Redetermination, Effective Date: The Words in Mom's Medicaid Letters

Eighteen terms in one plain line each, and what to write down about each.

Renewal, redetermination, effective date. The letters about Mom's Medicaid use words the family never needed before, and nobody hands you the glossary. These are the ones you're most likely to meet after approval, each in a plain line, with what to copy down when you see it.

Lines marked with a number come from a public source. The others say only what kind of thing the word names, because what it means for Mom depends on her state and on her letter. The definitions are for following the mail. They aren't for working out where Mom stands yourself.

The program and the people

Medicaid

A joint federal and state program that helps cover medical costs for certain groups of people, among them older adults and people with disabilities. Each state decides how to run its own, and it may have another name in your state. [1] [2]

WRITE DOWN What the program is called on Mom's letters.

State Medicaid agency

The office that runs Medicaid in Mom's state. Each state operates its own program, following federal rules, and Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN The agency's name, the phone number on Mom's letters, and the name of anyone you speak with.

Medicaid planner

In this roadmap, your Medicaid planner goes through the approval notice and the renewal requirements with the family, reviews significant changes with them, and holds a periodic review.

WRITE DOWN The questions you want to bring to the next review.

Elder law attorney

In this roadmap, the professional that legal questions go to. The Family Caregiver Alliance lists a local Area Agency on Aging, a state senior legal hotline, or an attorney who specializes in elder law as ways to find legal help. [5]

WRITE DOWN Any question that involves a legal document or a decision about property, so it can go to the attorney.

Words in the letters

Approval letter (approval notice)

The letter a state sends when it approves a person for Medicaid coverage. [1]

WRITE DOWN The date on it, every date it mentions, and where the original is kept.

Effective date

A date the approval letter gives under that name. What it covers for Mom is a question for the agency or your Medicaid planner.

WRITE DOWN The date exactly as written, and which letter it is in.

Ongoing obligations

The roadmap's words for whatever the approval letter says the family is to keep doing, sending or paying. What they are for Mom comes from her letter.

WRITE DOWN Each one in the letter's own words, with any date beside it.

Notice

A letter from the state about a person's coverage. The federal renewal flyer says it tells you whether a form has to be completed or other information sent. [6]

WRITE DOWN The date on it, what it asks for, any date it gives, and where you filed it.

Renewal

The state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify. States are required to do this periodically. [6] [7]

WRITE DOWN Any renewal date a letter gives, and which letter. If you can't find one, write that down as a question.

Redetermination

Used in the sources below for the same review as a renewal: the state determining again whether a person is eligible. [7]

WRITE DOWN Which word Mom's letters use, so you can use it when you call.

Coverage period

KFF explains that when a coverage period is ending the state sends a notice, and that if coverage was renewed automatically the notice gives the new coverage period. [8]

WRITE DOWN The start and end dates, if a letter gives them.

Renewal form or request for information

Something the state may send as part of a renewal. States are meant to use the data they already have first, and to send forms and requests for documents when that isn't enough. [6] [9]

WRITE DOWN The date it arrived, what it asks for, the date you answered, and where your copy is.

Change in circumstances

A change in a person's life after enrollment, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income. States have procedures for people to report changes that may affect eligibility. Which ones Mom's agency wants reported is for the agency to say. [7]

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and the question “does this need to be reported, and how?”

Fair hearing (appeal)

An administrative process that lets a person challenge certain Medicaid decisions made by their state. The state's written notice must say how to ask for one. [3]

WRITE DOWN The date on the notice, any date it gives, and where it is kept. Whether to ask for a hearing is a question for an elder law attorney.

Money and records

Unexpected funds

The roadmap's words for money nobody planned on: an inheritance, a gift received, the proceeds of a property sale, an insurance payment. No rule for how it is treated is given here. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility. [2]

WRITE DOWN What it is, who it came from, the date, and where it is now.

Records and the document system

A list of what is received and spent for Mom, with dates and reasons, kept with the receipts, the statements and the Medicaid mail. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests a safe, easily accessible place, with a trusted family member told where it is. [2] [10]

WRITE DOWN Where it is kept, who keeps it up, and who else knows.

Renewal calendar

In this roadmap, one calendar that holds the dates from Mom's letters, each with the letter it came from.

WRITE DOWN Every date a letter gives. Leave off any date that no letter or professional gave you.

Medicaid Maintenance Plan

What this step produces in the roadmap: the renewal calendar, the reporting requirements as they apply to Mom, a monitoring checklist, the document system and what the family does when something changes. It is put together with your Medicaid planner, and it isn't a decision about eligibility.

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet. Your folder, your calendar and your list of changes are what it starts from.

What this sheet doesn't do

It describes words. It doesn't say what any of them requires of your family, give a date or a limit, or tell you whether Mom still qualifies for anything. Those answers come from her own letters, the Medicaid agency and your Medicaid planner. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You can follow the letters now, and you know what to copy down from each one. The planning interview uses the same plain language: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Understanding Medicaid Fair Hearings
4. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, What should I do to help get my family member's legal and financial affairs in order?
6. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
7. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
8. KFF, Do I have to renew Medicaid coverage every year?
9. National Center on Law and Elder Rights (Administration for Community Living), Responding to Common Medicaid Unwinding Issues for Dual Eligibles
10. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness